Game development - Brackeys Game Jam 2026.1 Report

Tommaso Mattei

March 2026

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1 Introduction

Brackeys Game Jam was a game jam that went on from February 15 to February 21 of 2026. The theme of the game jam was Strange Places. Tne total participants were 14231. The cutoff to be eligible to win was for your game to have at least 20 ratings. After the end of the submission period there was a two week time frame for rating the games. The scoring system used had stars and they went from 1 to 5 for each category. The categories were: Audio, Visuals, Enjoyment Gameplay, Theme and Innovation. There were winners for each category but also an overall winner by averaging over all of them.



Figure 1: Brackeys Game Jam

2 The Dollhouse

The team made of Simone Maccari, Twigs and Zaphis created their first game together, the Dollhouse, an horroresque hack and slash with eerie vibes. Simone worked on 3D models, Twigs worked with programming, Ui and animation; Zaphis worked as a programmer. Both Twigs and Zaphis worked on SFX with the external help of Gattopiatto. Here's a link to the itch.io game page (https://twigs-28.itch.io/the-dollhouse). Below, the main menu of the game.

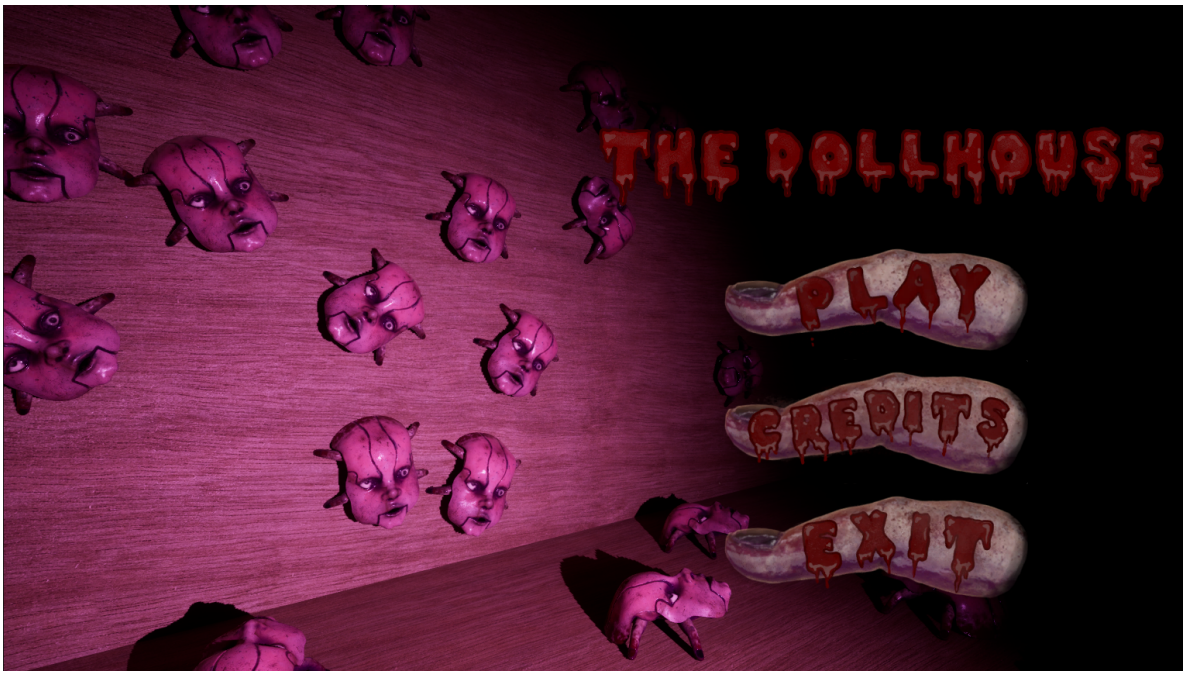


Figure 2: The main menu of The Dollhouse

The game plays in a waves format for which enemies of progressing difficulty spawn each time until all of them are defeated. The player has a first person point of view and can attack with his sword and can also use a ranged dagger. By being hit by certain moves and standing near dangerous artifacts the player will fall into madness, divided in multiple levels. At each level of madness the scenery or the player's view will change making the game harder and stranger.

3 Score and feedback analysis

Below, the final rankings and the rating distribution over 44 ratings, ending up overall in 499th place, being in the top 34.87%.

Table 1: Criteria Rankings and Scores (Ranked from 44 ratings)

Criteria	Rank	Score
Theme	#155	3.886
Gameplay	#438	3.023
Visuals	#456	3.455
Overall	#499	3.163
Enjoyment	#566	3.023
Audio	#595	2.841
Innovation	#648	2.750

Table 2: Rating Distribution

Rating	Percentage
5 star	18.9%
4 star	16.7%
3 star	34.5%
2 star	21.6%
1 star	8.3%

3.1 Score

The best scoring category category was Theme, with a 3.886 score and the 155th place, showing how the game had a strong direction and a perfect match with the game jam's request.

The second higher ranking was on the gameplay itself, with a 3.023 score and the 438th place. This is a relevant result since the most important aspect which we focused on for this jam were the mechanics and the gameplay itself, which paid off.

The third place was occupied by the Visuals, with a 3.455 score and the 456th place, which can be attributed to the impressive 3D models and the entire level and UI's visual presentation.

From the fourth place and downwards this was under the curve for our overall score, meaning that these categories diminished the final rank.

Enjoyment scored in the same way as gameplay, which definelty makes sense and it's in line with our thoughts, but ended up ranking lower in the 566th place because of the competition.

Audio had a score of 2.841 and the 595th place. This result was to be expected since the game itself had no background music during combat. Even though the rest of the SFX were there, such a thing is too big to ignore for most players and definetly had an impact, possibly on the enjoyment of the experience as well.

In last place we have Innovation, with a score of 2.750 and the 648th place. This result was kind of unexpected since it scored even lower than the audio itself. While it's true that the hack and slash formula wasn't really touched and varied too much, and this is certainly part of the problem, the madness mechanics were unique and definetly innovative in themselves. Our theory is that most of the playerbase did not engage enough with the madness mechanic due to the accumulation rate being too low and too easy to avoid, which is a balance oversight.

3.2 Feedback Analysis

Under the game's entry in the game jam page we received 34 comments containing feedback and impressions about the game, which can truly give us insight on the experience the players had and the reasoning behind the scores without having to guess. This section is divided with the same criteria used for scoring. Some categories like audio, gameplay and visuals are easy to judge from a comment while theme, innovation and enjoyment are more abstract. If a single comment touches multiple aspects it will be mentioned in all of them.

3.2.1 Audio

3 people said that they liked the SFX (since we had no music).

A comment said that the SFX were okay but that the lack of music during gameplay was quite boring. 2 more wanted the music for more intense battling.

A comment thought that adding fade out to the SFX would make them smoother without immediately cutting off.

A comment thought that an additional SFX for hitting an enemy was necessary to feel better the contact with it.

3.2.2 Gameplay

7 people said that they liked the gameplay and combat.

In particular two comments praised the presence of health collectibles through the level itself.

5 comments liked the feeling of throwing the dagger. Another comment said that they also liked how the sword slashes felt.

A comment liked dashing. Beyond that it also liked having different enemy types for a more diverse experience.

4 comments wanted a crosshair when aiming with the ranged dagger.

A comment thought that having power ups between waves or during the gameplay would have been more engaging.

2 comments thought about adding knockback while getting hit.

A comment wanted to add a stamina bar (which is debatable).

A comment would have liked more incentives for exploring and using the arena such as more pickups and necessary items.

3.2.3 Visuals

9 people said that they enjoyed the visual aspect of the game.

A comment liked the cohesion between the level itself and the enemies.

A comment liked the particles effect of the projectiles and proposed adding more effects while hitting an enemy for better feedback.

A comment thought that having a better cover art for the game would have helped its visibility.

7 comments liked the enemies models.

3 comments liked the lighting.

A comment believed that the speed of the enemies (probably the toy soldiers) was not synchronized with their animation an so it felt like they were sliding. They also didn't like being able to see the sky at the beginning and they felt like it ruined the atmosphere.

3 comments would have liked better animations. A comment in particular mentioned walk animations and attacks.

A comment liked the animations.

A comment thought that adding a visual effect when low on health would have helped.

A comment thought that keeping texel density consistent might help the assets seem more unified. Some colors and materials didn't gel together with others, which is way it proposed to implement LUTs for final pass colour grading.

3.2.4 Theme

15 people said that the game was strange or in line with the theme of the game jam (strange places).

3.2.5 Innovation

3 people said that they interacted with the madness mechanic or said the game was unique/innovative.

A comment said that the game was a bit basic. Another comment said it was simple.

3.2.6 Enjoyment

14 people said that they generally liked and enjoyed the game.

A comment said that they enjoyed doing parkour at the top of the map.

A comment said that a game breaking bug stopped its experience after a few rounds without being able to attack anymore.

A comment said that they got stuck on the first wave because they could not find one of the remaining enemies. Another comment said that they didn't get stuck but that sometimes the enemies would get stuck.

3 comments said that their PC had some trouble running the game. (one of them had a 3050)

4 Conclusion

The feedback itself clarifies the reason behind the scores and gives suggestion towards which way to improve the game itself.

4.1 Criteria

The theme was great and no one had anything to complain about it, everything flowed together really well and it was clearly the strongest point about the game.

The gameplay was liked and the movement and attacks performed by the player were satisfying, especially the dagger throwing (which could be improved by a crosshair). The level design and collectables were appreciated. To improve on this aspect having more things to do while exploring the arena, such as power ups, or even between waves could make the gameplay less linear and stagnant. Some minors improvement could be had by influencing feedback between hitting and getting hit.

The visuals were enjoyed by most people, in particular the enemies models and the atmosphere created by lighting and environment. A point of improvement here is on the animation of the enemies. No one had anything to say about the UI and if it wasn't confusing that's good enough for now.

Most people enjoyed the game. While it's hard to pinpoint a specific aspect that heightens or lowers the enjoyment of a game, since it's the union of all the other aspects, some extremely impactful issues on this are game breaking bugs and PC performance. Bugs should be kept to minimum with a more extensive play testing and by making use of the 2 days grace period for bug fixing after the submission. As for the performance, it should not be dismissed as many other Unreal engine developers did in their game's comments but it should be handled better, maybe even dipping in C++ code.

The audio reception was fairly terrible. While the SFX themselves were certainly fine, the lack of music during the gameplay is the number one thing that any player will notice which will terribly impact the score. Beyond polishing the SFX it's imperative to have songs playing during the game no matter what.

The innovation was the lowest scoring of all categories and we can understand why. Only two comments mentioned the madness mechanic, which was the main selling point of the game that separated itself from another common hack and slash. It is probable that the falling off rate of the madness was too high or unnecessary given the slow madness rate build up of the artifacts. Dodging enemies' projectiles was fairly easy which meant that most players probably did not even get a single instance of madness. To be sure of this a few gameplay playest should be recored with first time players to see their reactions and their interaction with the madness mechanic. I do not believe that the game itself was not innovative or obvious, but that some fine tuning of the numbers of the mechanic would have made it way more prominent and it would have impacted the score way more.

4.2 End

While some of these comments are only useful in this specific kind of game genre and presentation there are still many lessons that can be brought forth in the next project. Since this is our first game it still shows very promising results and many points to improve on.